

pecially its vivid reds and ochre, and its segmented composition, and used them to invent a new style of abstract landscape painting, well represented here by 'La Terre' (1979), 'Rajasthan' (1983) and the famously expensive large canvas 'Saurashtra' (1983).

Before the end of the '80s, he had encountered the *bindu*, which was to become his major inspiration for the rest of his life, driving his career's last and longest phase, spanning two and a half decades. We see the experimental beginnings of it here with 'Gestation' (1988) and its mature development in 'Surya Namaskar' (1993). Raza's engagement with Tantra opens up whole new realms of resonance. There is scope, at least, for a profundity that we do not expect from a joyful landscape, along with the risk of leaving the uninitiated viewer bewildered.

What holds it together is the connection with his earlier work. The colourful geometry is back, centre-stage. So too is the free handling. For despite the intricate and carefully structured pattern, his is not the ruled line of a Mondrian; it is more like the living line of a woven textile. The vast triptych which closes the exhibition, 'Bindu-Naad' (1995) depicts the vibrations of the *bindu* on a monumental scale. For some, this work will sound the reverberations of Om. Those who cannot share in that quest may think of it rather in terms of landscape: as Raza's Giverny moment. These are ripples on the surface of his pond, distracting us from what lurks beneath. ■

– Giles Tillotson

(Traversing Space: Here and Beyond, an exhibition by KNMA, continues at Bikaner House until June 30)

Brush With Tantra

By collecting the works of 16 artists, a Delhi exhibition is helping viewers join the dots of a tantric pattern

It seems ironic that when modern, urban Indians hear the word 'Tantra', they first think of flower power and sex, of Allen Ginsberg, the Beatles, Jimmi Hendrix and Sting. The primness with which most Indians treat Tantra is based more on these superficial associations than on what it is—a system of observances through which the nature of the divine and its manifestation in human reality are explored. Unsurprisingly, the study of Tantra has grown in the West—an Instagram search for terms like 'Shivashakti', 'Mahavidyas' and 'kundalini' is proof of this—but in India, there is almost no discourse that gives Tantra recognition, either as a spiritual or an artistic practice.

On view at DAG, Delhi, until June 27, *Tantra on the Edge: Inspirations and Experiments in Twentieth-Century Indian Art* is as appealing as it is important. With works by 16 artists—S.H. Raza, Satish Gujral, Manu Parekh, Shobha Broota, G.R. Santosh, Biren De *et al*—the exhibition reveals how they and their art had a connection to Tantra philosophy, its abstract, sacred symbols, its colours, its gods and goddesses. Even if it weren't for the *yantras* (tantric designs and objects) that DAG displays, Tantra's influence seems obvious in the works you see—in Prabhakar Barwe's exquisite sarees made for the Weavers Guild, Parekh's wild sculptures made from found objects, and Gujral's granite and ceramic mandalas and sculpture that use the mantra 'Hrim'.

The exhibition reveals how the artists and their art had a connection to Tantra philosophy, its abstract, sacred symbols, its colours

The sheer exuberance and vivid colours seem enough to draw you in, but the stories of how these artists came to study and incorporate Tantra in their work are, at times, more fascinating. Born into a Kashmiri Muslim family, G.R. Santosh changed his name—'Ghulam Rasool'—when he married his childhood sweetheart, Santosh. After going on an Amarnath *yatra* in 1964, he soon turned to Tantric art and Kashmir Shaivism. Known as 'the father of neo-tantrism', he went on to create iconic modern Tantric paintings, many of which were later exhibited internationally.

Jyoti Bhatt, on the other hand, approached Tantra with a sense of humour. While in the US, he was once commissioned to create 100 prints with a spiritual intent. Rejecting the offer, he went on to create Tantra-inspired artworks that resembled pop-art of the day. With tongue firmly in cheek, he labelled one painting, 'I am a Pseudo-Tantric'.

Since none of the featured artists ever made explicit their interest in Tantra, it became hard to join these dots of influence. You start to see a pattern only when you see all their artworks displayed together. *Tantra on the Edge* took over 12 years to put together. When viewed in conjunction with curator Madhu Khanna's incredible catalogue, it shows how quietly pervasive the idea of 'Tantra' was—regardless of where the artist was based, in Europe or India, in Banaras or Delhi. ■

–Ritika Kochhar







Tantric Touch
(clockwise from top) 'Khotiyar Mata' by Jyoti Bhatt, Untitled by G.R. Santosh, 'The Moment' by Biren De